sex and averaging their deviations from 100 irrespective of sign and (c) computi[ng] the index which is obtained as three times the sex ratio score added to the two [age] ratio scores.

The sex ratio scores, age ratio scores for each sex and the age accuracy index computed for the quinquennial age distributions of selected censuses from 1921 are given in Table 5.2. The Index shows a continuous decline from a high o[f] 97.5 in 1921 to 25.6 in 1971. Since a lower score indicates greater accuracy in the age distribution, it may be concluded that there has been a considerable improvement in accuracy of the data by age groups.

TABLE 5.2 : AGE ACCURACY INDEX BY THE U.N. SECRETARIAT METHOD
SRI LANKA CENSUSES OF 1921, 1946, 1953, 1963 & 1971

Census		Sex Ratio Score	Age Ratio Score Male	Age Ratio Score Female	Age Accuracy Index (Joint Scores)
1921	T	22.0	14.1	17.4	97.5
1946	T	9.6	12.2	11.3	52.3
1953	T	4.4	8.8	11.0	33.0
1963	T	4.2	7.3	8.4	28.3
1971	T	4.1	5.4	7.9	25.6

5.4 Differentials in age composition

Statistical data on age composition are best presented by frequency curve[s] and age pyramids (see Charts 5.1 & 5.2). Because ageing is a process rather tha[n] a trait, averages are comparatively meaningless except for gross description.Part[i]cularly since a wide variety of different patterns in frequency distribution are possible in the age composition with little difference in them, averages like med[ian] age, mean age etc. of a population, are not too useful in the study of age compos[it]ion.

A frequency curve of age composition can be presented in various ways,bu[t] [th]e common method is to plot age on the axis of abscissa and number or percent on [th]e axis of ordinate. The area on the graph surrounded by the curve and axis represents the population (see Chart 5.1). As a result of the addition to the population by births at the age zero and decrease of population through deaths at all subsequent ages but more at older ages, every year the age curve will decline slowly with the advance of age unless it is disturbed by a sudden change in the factors of fertility, mortality and migration.

An age pyramid or a population pyramid is another way of presenting the age composition graphically. In this case a histogram is used more frequently tha[n] a frequency curve. Age groups are arranged in strata with the lowest age at the bottom and the highest at the top, each divided customarily between males at the left and females at the right (see Chart 5.2).

Usually a pyramid thus obtained is broad at the base and tapers gradually towards the top. The pyramid for Sri Lanka in 1971 is an expanding type - a typica[l] shape of a population with high birth rates or slightly declining birth rates and